

Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός

Aelian of Praeneste on Animals and Varied History

eul_aid: ria

Period: [Ῥωμαϊκή](#) [Roman](#)
Dialect: [Κοινή](#) [Koine](#)
Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)
Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)
Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Claudius Aelianus, known as Aelian, was a Roman author and rhetorician of the late second and early third centuries CE. Born in the Italian town of Praeneste, he wrote exclusively in Greek and was a prominent figure in the Second Sophistic, a cultural movement that revered classical Greek language and learning. He served as a priest and was a friend of the historian Cassius Dio. Renowned for his eloquent Attic Greek, he earned the nickname "honey-tongued." Aelian famously claimed he never traveled beyond Italy, dedicating his life to study and writing in Rome.

His surviving works are compilations of stories and facts designed to entertain and educate. **On the Nature of Animals** is a 17-book collection of animal lore, blending natural history with moral fables. **Various History** is a 14-book miscellany of anecdotes about famous people, customs, and curiosities from the Greek world. He also wrote a surviving set of 20 fictional **Rustic Letters** about country life. Other works, including a speech titled **Indictment of the Effeminate**, are lost.

Modern scholars note that Aelian's historical importance lies not in original analysis but in his role as a preserver. His writings are valuable repositories of excerpts from many earlier Greek texts that are now lost. They provide key insights into ancient beliefs, folklore, and the intellectual tastes of the educated, Greek-speaking elite within the Roman Empire.

Works (4)

- [Ἀποσπασμάτια](#) · [Excerpts](#) · 233 passages
- [ἐκ τῶν Αἰλιανοῦ ἀγροικικῶν ἐπιστολῶν](#) · [From Aelian's Rustic Letters](#) · 20 passages
- [Περὶ ζῴων ιδιότητος](#) · [On the Nature of Animals](#) · 781 passages
- [Ποικίλη ἱστορία](#) · [Varied History](#) · 408 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- [Ἀχιλλεὺς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς](#) · [Achilles Tatius of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος](#) · [Aelius Aristides of Smyrna](#) · 3 works
- [Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς](#) · [Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus](#) · 1 work
- [Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής](#) · [Aelius Theon the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς](#) · [Alcidamas of Elaea](#) · 1 work

- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · Alciphron the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · Alexander Son of Numenius · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Alexander the Ephesian Poet · 1 work
- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Antiphon of Athens · 9 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ῥαμνούσιος · Antiphon of Rhamnus · 1 work